

Nimzo-Indian

The Rubinstein 4.e3: center, bishop pair, and structural judgment

THE PROMISE

Allow the Nimzo confidently, meet every major setup with one coherent development scheme, and understand when doubled c-pawns are strength rather than damage.

COURSE VOLUME 05 OF 10

SEE THE POSITION | RECALL THE PLAN | CALCULATE THE MOVE

What this volume should change

- Use 4.e3 and 5.Bd3 as the stable foundation against the Nimzo-Indian.
- Handle ...d5, ...c5, ...b6, ...Bxc3, and ...Ne4 move orders without losing central control.
- Use the bishop pair and broad center while preventing Black from blockading doubled c-pawns.
- Recognize QGD transpositions before inventing a separate plan.

STUDY METHOD

Learn each chapter in three layers: first the trigger and plan, then the short main line, then Black's branches. Hide the page and reconstruct the line on a board. Do not memorize notation without the position's purpose.

Inside this volume

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Original instructional synthesis. Move sequences were legality-checked with python-chess and critical choices were reviewed with Stockfish 18. Opening-frequency context was checked against the Lichess opening explorer in September 2026. Engines verify tactics; the explanations and training design are the course's teaching layer. Diagrams use Colin M. L. Burnett's Cburnett piece artwork as distributed by Lichess under GPLv2+.

CHAPTER 01

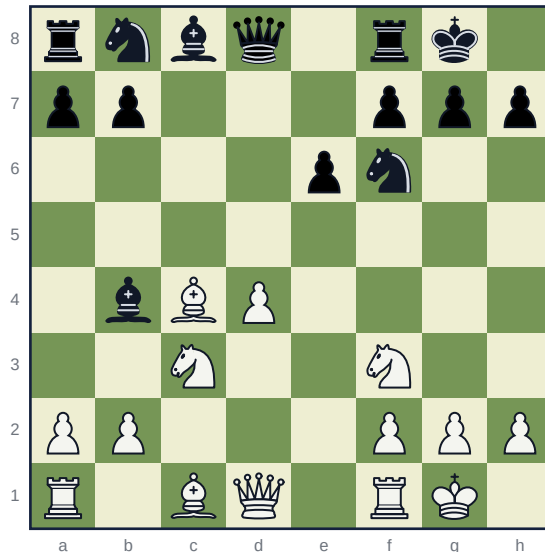
The Rubinstein spine

POSITION TRIGGER

1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4: Black pins Nc3 and threatens structural damage.

Your anchor line

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Bb4 4. e3 O-O 5. Bd3 d5 6. Nf3 c5 7. O-O dxc4 8. Bxc4 cxd4 9. exd4



Repertoire position after the main line

Why this setup works

The Rubinstein Variation builds a classical center and develops the bishop to d3 before deciding the queen-knight route. White accepts that ...Bxc3 may double the c-pawns because the bishop pair and extra central support provide compensation. In the anchor line, exchanges create an isolated d-pawn but also active pieces and open files. The opening is about dynamic balance, not preserving a perfect pawn diagram.

White's plan

- Develop Bd3, Nf3, and O-O; solve king safety before exploiting the bishop pair.
- Use Qe2, Re1, and sometimes a3 to support e4 or ask the b4 bishop a useful question.
- If the center opens, value active piece squares and development over cosmetic pawn weaknesses.

What Black is trying to do

- ...d5 and ...c5 attack d4 before White can build e4.
- ...Bxc3 can damage the structure and create c4/c3 targets.
- ...dxc4 followed by ...cxd4 may leave White with an isolated pawn but active lines.

Branch map

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
4...O-O	5.Bd3. Keep options against ...d5, ...c5, and ...b6.

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
4...c5	5.Bd3 Nc6 6.Nf3; develop before deciding d5 or O-O.
4...b6	5.Bd3 Bb7 6.f3, preparing e4 with care.
4...Bxc3+	5.bxc3. Accept the structure and build e4.

MOVE-ORDER DISCIPLINE

Do not play a3 simply to 'win the bishop pair.' The tempo matters, and Black may exchange only when doubled pawns become a target. Ask what a3 enables next.

MEMORY HOOK

e3 opens Bd3; castle; then turn structure into central play.

CHAPTER 02

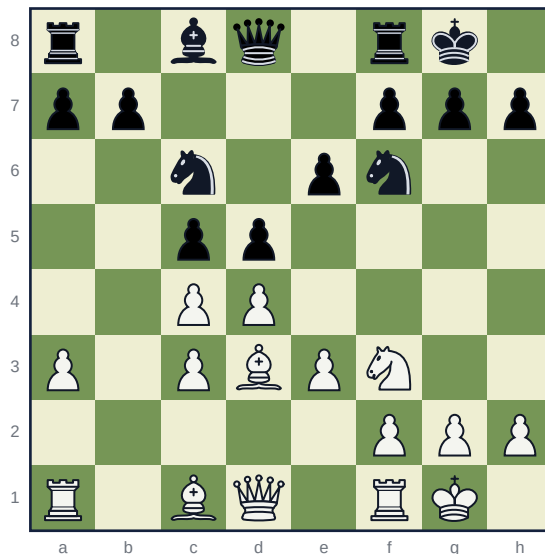
Classical ...d5 and ...c5

POSITION TRIGGER

Black occupies d5 and immediately pressures the center with ...c5.

Your anchor line

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Bb4 4. e3 O-O 5. Bd3 d5 6. Nf3 c5 7. O-O Nc6 8. a3 Bxc3 9. bxc3



Repertoire position after the main line

Why this setup works

The move a3 is useful after castling because the bishop's decision changes White's next plan. After ...Bxc3, bxc3 creates a powerful d4/e4 center and the b-file; White may play cxd5, c5, or e4 according to Black's setup. If the bishop retreats, White gains queenside space without exposing the king. The doubled pawns become weak only if Black blockades c4 and attacks c3 before White activates them.

White's plan

- Use a3 after castling, when the bishop's retreat or exchange creates a concrete gain.
- After bxc3, prepare e4 with Qc2/Re1 or use cxd5 to open the b2-h8 diagonal for the bishop.
- Advance c5 when it gains space and denies ...c5 pressure; keep c4 mobile when it can challenge d5.

What Black is trying to do

- ...Bxc3 creates c4/c3 targets and removes a center defender.
- ...dxc4 may isolate d4 after White recaptures Bxc4.
- ...Ne4 uses the pin and central squares to trade White's active pieces.

Branch map

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
7...Nc6	8.a3 asks the bishop after White is castled.

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
8...Bxc3	9.bxc3; use the b-file and central pawn mass.
8...Ba5	9.b4 Bc7 10.cxd5; queenside space has been gained with tempo.
...dxc4	Bxc4 and evaluate an IQP structure; activity comes before pawn defense.

MOVE-ORDER DISCIPLINE

The c-pawns are a connected mobile unit before they are fixed targets. Use one of them to challenge the center before Black blockades both.

MEMORY HOOK

After bxc3, move the pawns before Black fixes them.

CHAPTER 03

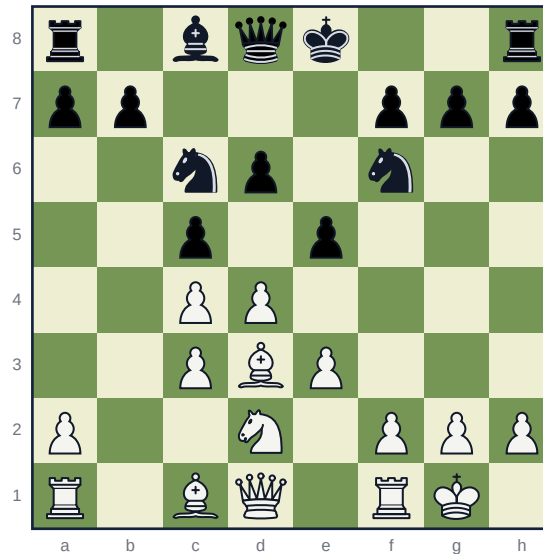
Hubner setup with ...c5 and ...Bxc3

POSITION TRIGGER

Black exchanges on c3 early and builds a dark-square blockade with ...d6 and ...e5.

Your anchor line

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Bb4 4. e3 c5 5. Bd3 Nc6 6. Nf3 Bxc3+ 7. bxc3 d6 8. O-O e5 9. Nd2



Repertoire position after the main line

Why this setup works

Black gives the bishop pair but fixes the center so the bishops lack open lines. White uses Nd2 to prepare f4 or e4 support and seeks a pawn break before the blockade settles. The critical strategic choice is whether to play d5, e4, or f4. A closed center favors maneuvering; opening the position without preparation can expose the doubled c-pawns.

White's plan

- Use Nd2 to support e4/f4 and keep the f-pawn available.
- Prepare d5 when it gains space and can be supported; prepare f4 when the center is locked.
- Place bishops on useful diagonals before opening the center; the bishop pair is valuable only with lines.

What Black is trying to do

- ...e5 fixes d4 and restricts the c1 bishop.
- ...b6 and ...Ba6 can exchange White's strong light bishop.
- ...O-O followed by ...Ne8 and ...f5 may attack White's center.

Branch map

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
4...c5	5.Bd3 Nc6 6.Nf3; preserve the option to castle.

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
6...Bxc3+	7.bxc3 d6 8.O-O. Complete safety before breaking.
...e5	9.Nd2 and prepare f4 or d5.
...b6	Use e4 and Qe2 before Black exchanges Bd3 with ...Ba6.

MOVE-ORDER DISCIPLINE

Do not celebrate the bishop pair while every pawn blocks it. Your next job is to prepare the correct pawn break.

MEMORY HOOK

Closed center: reroute Nd2, prepare a break, then release the bishops.

CHAPTER 04

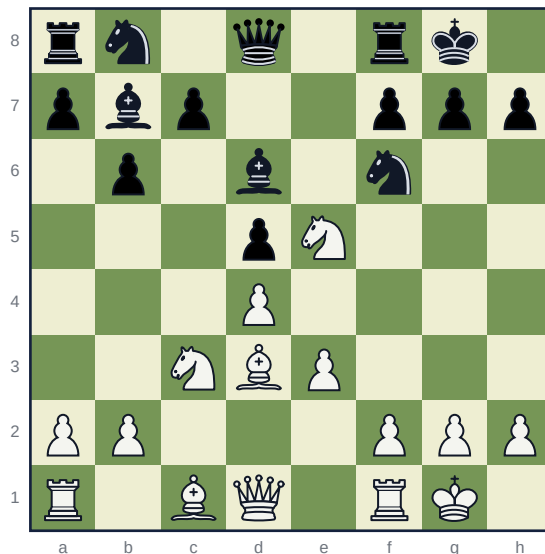
Romanishin ...b6 setup

POSITION TRIGGER

Black develops the queen bishop to b7 and delays the central commitment.

Your anchor line

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Bb4 4. e3 b6 5. Bd3 Bb7 6. Nf3 O-O 7. O-O d5 8. cxd5 exd5 9. Ne5 Bd6



Repertoire position after the main line

Why this setup works

The bishop on b7 increases pressure on e4, so White completes development before changing the center. After ...d5, cxd5 creates a familiar Exchange structure, and Ne5 occupies the central outpost. White may later use f3/e4, but only after castling and establishing the pieces. The plan resembles the QGD central-break method with the extra tactical fact that the b4 bishop can exchange on c3.

White's plan

- Castle before changing the center, then use cxd5 and Ne5 to gain stable central squares.
- Ask the b4 bishop with a3 only when the recapture or retreat helps the central plan.
- Prepare f3/e4 later with Qc2 and Re1 if Black cannot answer with ...c5 effectively.

What Black is trying to do

- ...d5 attacks the center and may exploit f3's weakening effect.
- ...Bxc3+ can damage the structure just before e4.
- ...dxc4 may open the b7 bishop against g2 and e4.

Branch map

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
4...b6	5.Bd3 Bb7 6.Nf3 completes development.

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
6...O-O	7.O-O. Secure the king before changing the center.
7...d5	8.cxd5 exd5 9.Ne5 occupies the central outpost.
...Bxc3+	bxc3 supports d4/e4; use the center before it becomes fixed.

MOVE-ORDER DISCIPLINE

Do not play f3 merely because the b7 bishop eyes e4. First castle and create a stable central outpost; prepare the pawn break afterward.

MEMORY HOOK

Against ...b6: develop, castle, exchange into a familiar center, and occupy e5.

CHAPTER 05

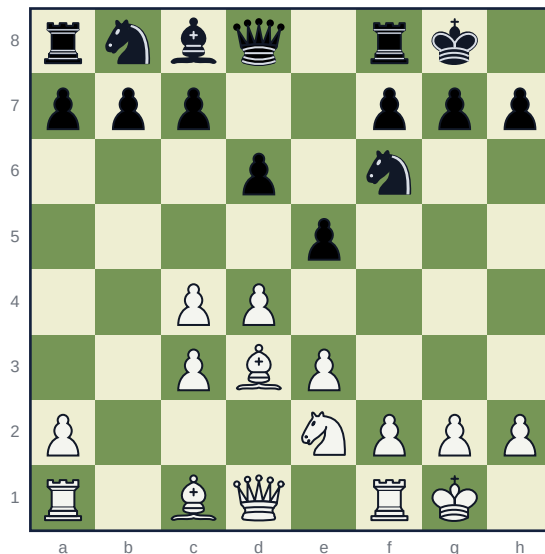
Immediate ...Bxc3+

POSITION TRIGGER

Black exchanges the bishop before castling or choosing a central structure.

Your anchor line

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Bb4 4. e3 Bxc3+ 5. bxc3 d6 6. Bd3 e5 7. Ne2 O-O 8. O-O



Repertoire position after the main line

Why this setup works

White receives the bishop pair and a strong central pawn mass without Black first gaining a tempo from ...c5. Ne2 supports f4 and keeps the f-pawn flexible. The doubled c-pawns control important squares and can support d5, but Black will try to blockade c4/c3. White should use the space before simplifying into a static endgame.

White's plan

- Develop Bd3 and Ne2, then castle before playing e4 or f4.
- Use d5 to gain space if Black cannot undermine with ...c6 or ...c5 effectively.
- Open the b-file with Rb1 and support a queenside advance when the center is stable.

What Black is trying to do

- ...e5 fixes the center and prepares ...Nc6-a5 against c4.
- ...b6 and ...Ba6 seek the valuable light bishop.
- ...c5 can blockade c4 and pressure the doubled pawns.

Branch map

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
4...Bxc3+	5.bxc3. The bishop pair and center are the compensation.

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
5...d6	6.Bd3; prepare e4 and castle.
5...c5	6.Bd3 d5 7.Nf3; keep c4 mobile and challenge d5.
...b6	Use e4 quickly enough that ...Ba6 does not exchange your best bishop for free.

MOVE-ORDER DISCIPLINE

Avoid automatic c5, which can lock your own bishop out and leave c3 backward. Advance only when it gains a durable square or denies a real break.

MEMORY HOOK

Early bishop pair means use the center before Black builds the blockade.

CHAPTER 06

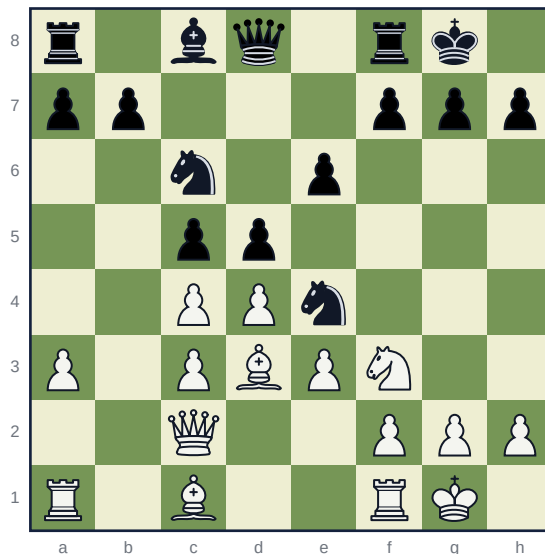
Black centralizes with ...Ne4

POSITION TRIGGER

Black places a knight on e4 while Nc3 is pinned or after the center is closed.

Your anchor line

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Bb4 4. e3 O-O 5. Bd3 d5 6. Nf3 c5 7. O-O Nc6 8. a3 Bxc3 9. bxc3 Ne4 10. Qc2



Repertoire position after the main line

Why this setup works

The e4 knight is active because it attacks c3 and may support ...f5. White challenges it with Qc2, Nd2, or cxd5 followed by Bxe4. f3 is possible only when the king and e3 square are secure. Exchanging the centralized knight often helps the bishop pair, but not if it leaves Black a powerful protected pawn on e4.

White's plan

- Use Qc2 to attack e4 and h7 simultaneously.
- Prepare Nd2 or Bxe4 after changing the center so the recapture favors White.
- Play f3 only after calculating ...Nxc3 and ...dxc4 tactics.

What Black is trying to do

- ...f5 reinforces e4 and creates a kingside Stonewall shell.
- ...Nxc3 can damage the structure further and remove a defender of d5/e4.
- ...dxc4 opens the bishop and may expose d4 after White moves the queen.

Branch map

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
...Ne4	Qc2 attacks the knight and creates a second threat on h7.

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
...f5	Use f3 or cxd5 only after checking king safety; attack the dark squares.
...Nxc3	Qxc3 or bxc3 according to which recapture preserves the center.
...dxc4	Bxc4 and then challenge e4; do not fight both centers at once without development.

MOVE-ORDER DISCIPLINE

A centralized knight is not refuted by chasing it with pawns if those pawn moves create larger holes. Attack it with pieces and change its support.

MEMORY HOOK

Pressure e4 twice, remove its pawn support, then exchange or expel it.

CHAPTER 07

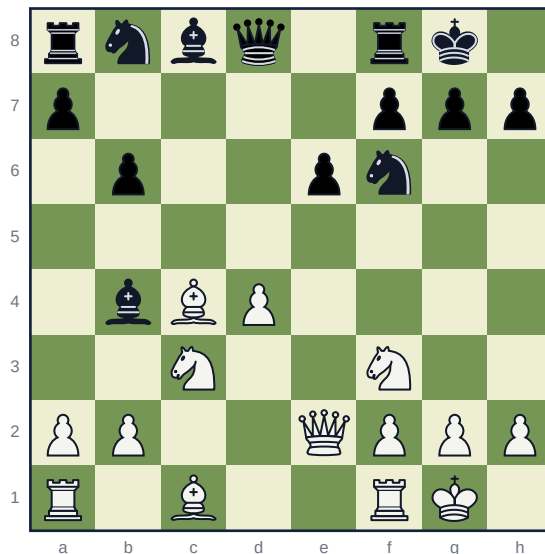
Isolated d-pawn positions

POSITION TRIGGER

Central exchanges leave White with a pawn on d4 and no c- or e-pawn neighbor.

Your anchor line

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Bb4 4. e3 O-O 5. Bd3 d5 6. Nf3 c5 7. O-O dxc4 8. Bxc4 cxd4 9. exd4 b6 10. Qe2



Repertoire position after the main line

Why this setup works

White's isolated d-pawn grants open files, active squares, and the d5 advance. Black wants to blockade d5/d4 and exchange pieces. Qe2 supports Ne5 and Rd1; Bg5 can increase pressure. White should seek active play before mass exchanges make the pawn purely weak. The decision is often whether d5 opens lines at the right moment or merely liquidates White's space.

White's plan

- Place rooks on d1/e1, queen on e2, and a knight on e5 when safe.
- Use d5 when it opens bishops or creates a tactical threat against the king.
- Avoid exchanges that leave a passive queen-and-rook defense of d4 without active compensation.

What Black is trying to do

- ...b6 and ...Bb7 blockade the long diagonal and increase d5 control.
- ...Nbd7 and ...Bb7 prepare ...Rc8 and pressure d4.
- Piece exchanges reduce White's attacking potential and expose the isolated pawn.

Branch map

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
...b6	Qe2 and Bg5; use development to support d5.

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
...Bb7	Rfd1 and Rac1; improve pieces before the break.
...Nbd7	Ne5 can seize an outpost if exchanges do not concede d4.
...Bxc3	bxc3 may create hanging pawns; keep them mobile and active.

MOVE-ORDER DISCIPLINE

Do not defend d4 with every piece. If all pieces become guards, Black has achieved the blockade without calculation.

MEMORY HOOK

IQP: activity now, d5 when it opens lines, avoid sterile exchanges.

CHAPTER 08

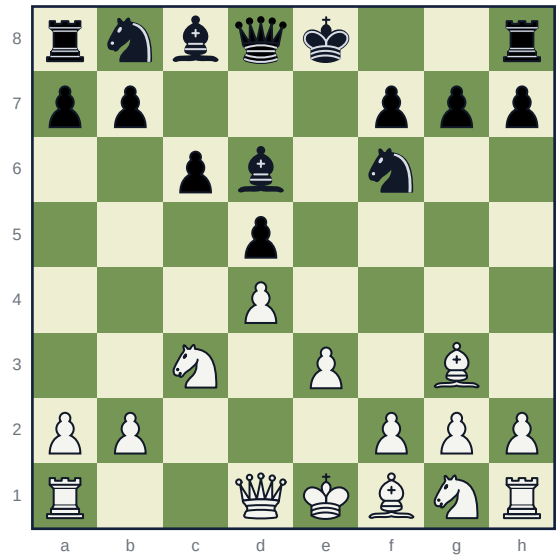
Move-order transpositions

POSITION TRIGGER

Black delays ...Bb4, inserts ...d5, or returns to QGD structures.

Your anchor line

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 d5 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Bf4 c6 6. e3 Bd6 7. Bg3



Repertoire position after the main line

Why this setup works

After 3...d5 there is no Nimzo pin, so use the QGD Exchange repertoire. If Black plays ...Bb4 after cxd5, use the Ragozin-style chapter. If ...c5 appears before ...d5, use the Hubner or Tarrasch logic based on whether Black has exchanged Bxc3. The goal is to recognize structural identity before recalling a named line.

White's plan

- Transpose to the QGD whenever Black commits ...d5 and no special tactic changes cxd5.
- Use the same Bf4/e3/Bd3 hierarchy in Exchange structures.
- Use the Nimzo bishop-pair logic only if ...Bb4 and ...Bxc3 actually occur.

What Black is trying to do

- Move-order changes can improve ...Bf5 or ...c5 by a tempo.
- An inserted ...Bb4 can pin Nc3 during an e4 break.
- An early ...c5 may create a Tarrasch-like IQP rather than a Nimzo structure.

Branch map

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
3...d5	4.cxd5 and use the QGD Exchange volume.

BLACK CHOOSES	YOUR RESPONSE AND PURPOSE
4...Bb4	Use e3, Bd3, and Nge2; treat the pin concretely.
3...c5	5.Bd3 and develop; decide d5 only after ...Nc6 or ...d5.
...Bxc3+	Only then switch to doubled-c-pawn plans.

MOVE-ORDER DISCIPLINE

A repertoire should shrink transpositions, not multiply them. One structure belongs to one mental file regardless of the opening label shown by software.

MEMORY HOOK

No ...Bxc3, no doubled-pawn plan; ...d5 means QGD map.

Repertoire Test

For every position, name the opening branch, state your strategic objective, and choose a move. The answer is not only a move: it is a move attached to a reason.

TEST 01 | Accept the structure

What is White's urgent strategic task before Black fixes the doubled c-pawns?



Position reached by: 1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Bb4 4. e3 O-O 5. Bd3 d5 6. Nf3 c5 7. O-O Nc6 8. a3 Bxc3 9. bxc3

WRITE BEFORE CHECKING

1) the cue, 2) at least two candidates, 3) Black's strongest reply, and 4) the plan you expect after the move.

TEST 02 | Hubner blockade

Which knight maneuver supports White's main pawn breaks?



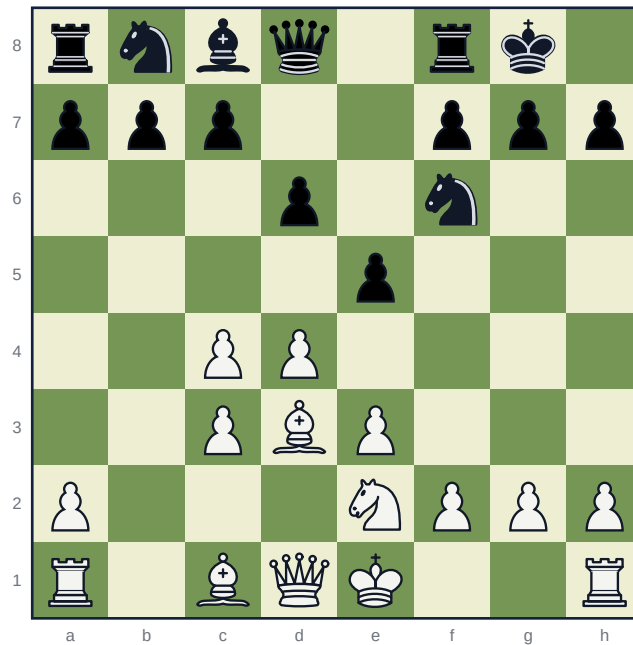
Position reached by: 1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Bb4 4. e3 c5 5. Bd3 Nc6 6. Nf3 Bxc3+ 7. bxc3 d6 8. O-O e5

WRITE BEFORE CHECKING

1) the cue, 2) at least two candidates, 3) Black's strongest reply, and 4) the plan you expect after the move.

TEST 03 | Center over cosmetics

Why are the doubled pawns not yet a weakness?



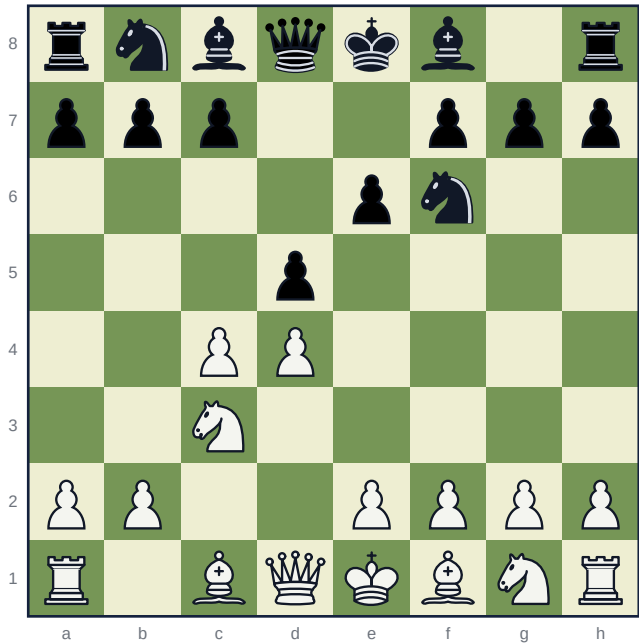
Position reached by: 1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Bb4 4. e3 Bxc3+ 5. bxc3 d6 6. Bd3 e5 7. Ne2 O-O

WRITE BEFORE CHECKING

1) the cue, 2) at least two candidates, 3) Black's strongest reply, and 4) the plan you expect after the move.

TEST 04 | Recognize the transposition

Which volume now supplies the move and plan?



Position reached by: 1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 d5

WRITE BEFORE CHECKING

1) the cue, 2) at least two candidates, 3) Black's strongest reply, and 4) the plan you expect after the move.

Repertoire Test - Answers

TEST 01 | Accept the structure

Use the pawn mass: prepare e4, cxd5, or c5 according to the center. The bishop pair needs open lines, and the c-pawns need mobility before blockade.

TEST 02 | Hubner blockade

Play 9.Nd2, supporting f4 and e4 while keeping the f-pawn free. White must prepare a break to release the bishops.

TEST 03 | Center over cosmetics

They control central squares and support d5/e4 while White owns the bishop pair and b-file. They become weak only if fixed and blockaded. White should castle and use the center.

TEST 04 | Recognize the transposition

Use the QGD Exchange repertoire: 4.cxd5 exd5 5.Bf4. The move order began as an Indian defense, but the structure is the deciding fact.

One-Page Recall Card

Cover the right column. Read the trigger and say the memory hook. Then cover the left column and reconstruct which position produces that hook.

1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 e6 3.Nc3 Bb4: Black pins Nc3 and threatens structural damage.	e3 opens Bd3; castle; then turn structure into central play.
Black occupies d5 and immediately pressures the center with ...c5.	After bxc3, move the pawns before Black fixes them.
Black exchanges on c3 early and builds a dark-square blockade with ...d6 and ...e5.	Closed center: reroute Nd2, prepare a break, then release the bishops.
Black develops the queen bishop to b7 and delays the central commitment.	Against ...b6: develop, castle, exchange into a familiar center, and occupy e5.
Black exchanges the bishop before castling or choosing a central structure.	Early bishop pair means use the center before Black builds the blockade.
Black places a knight on e4 while Nc3 is pinned or after the center is closed.	Pressure e4 twice, remove its pawn support, then exchange or expel it.
Central exchanges leave White with a pawn on d4 and no c- or e-pawn neighbor.	IQP: activity now, d5 when it opens lines, avoid sterile exchanges.
Black delays ...Bb4, inserts ...d5, or returns to QGD structures.	No ...Bxc3, no doubled-pawn plan; ...d5 means QGD map.

SPACED REVIEW

Review today, tomorrow, after three days, after one week, and after one month. A chapter graduates only when you can reconstruct its anchor line and explain its plan without looking.

GAME TRANSFER

After every serious game, locate the first position where your memory ended. Study from that exact fork. This turns the repertoire into a living system while keeping the PDFs as the stable foundation.